Unit 5

Syncopation

New: Notes that start between the beats: ties over the beat and the bar line, accents

Most notes so far started on a beat. A syncopated note starts between two beats and holds through the next one, so the accent falls where you do not expect it. Syncopation gives ragtime, jazz and many dances their bounce. The secret is to keep the beat completely steady underneath: the syncopation only works against a beat that does not move.

What is new

Eighth, quarter, eighth

Count 1-and-2-and: the quarter note starts on 'and' and lasts through beat 2. Clap it first: short-LONG-short.

Accents

The sign > over or under a note means: play it a little louder. In this unit it marks the syncopated notes.

Ties over the beat and the bar line

A note tied over the bar line starts early, on the last 'and' of the bar, and is not played again on beat 1. This 'anticipation' is the sound of ragtime.

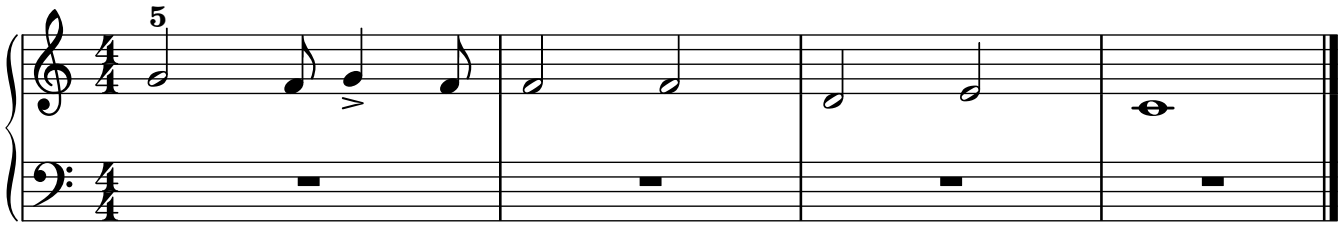
Reading tips

1. Count out loud, with the 'and's, the first few times: 1-and-2-and-3-and-4-and.
2. Let the left hand play exactly on the beats; the right hand's accents fall between them.
3. At a tie over the bar line, feel beat 1 in the left hand while the right hand holds.

Part A: Off the beat ♩ = 60

Right hand alone in C position: syncopated rhythms with accents.

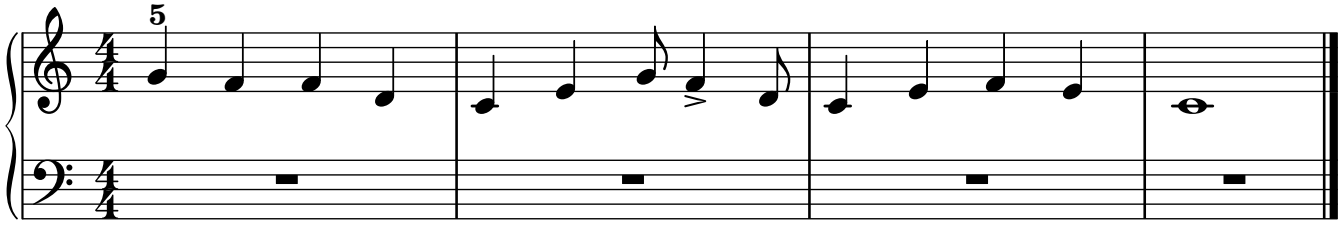
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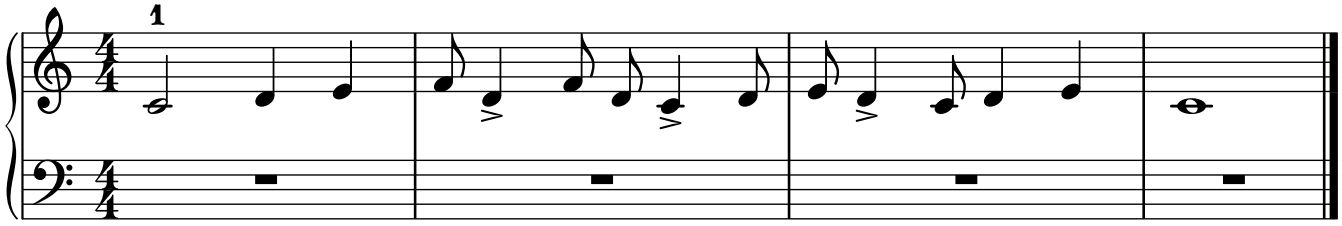
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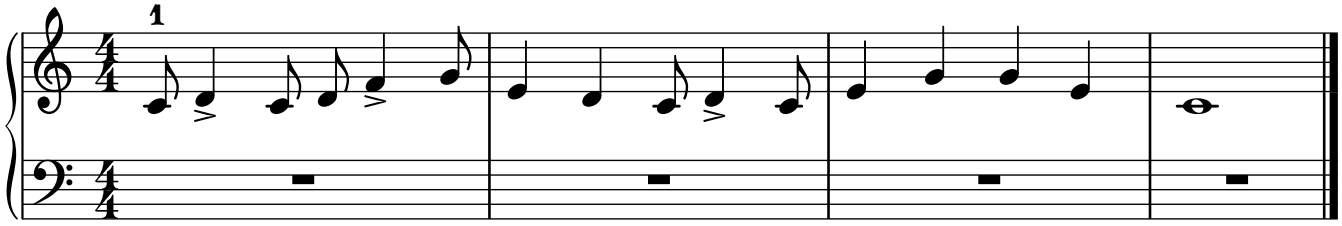
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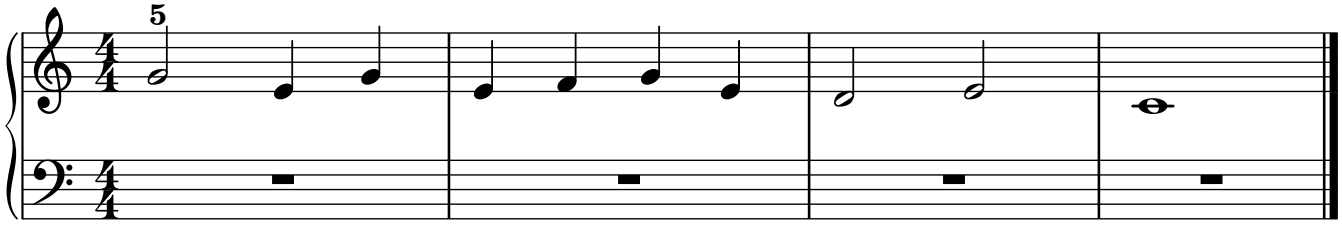
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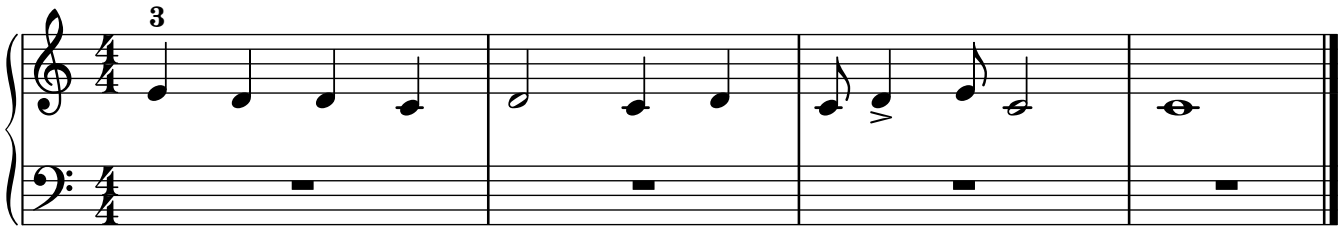
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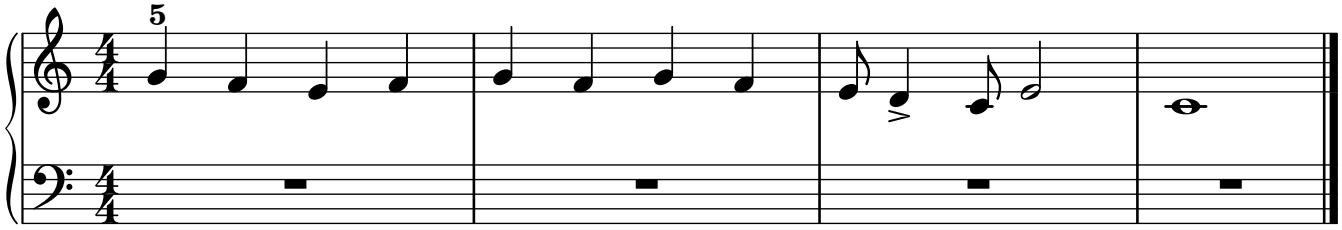
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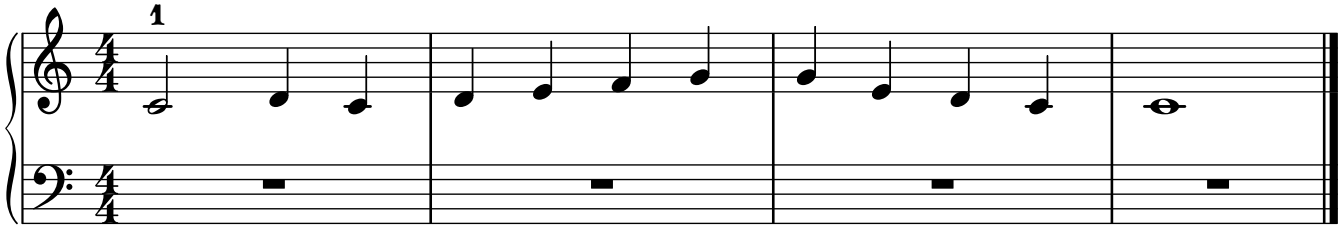
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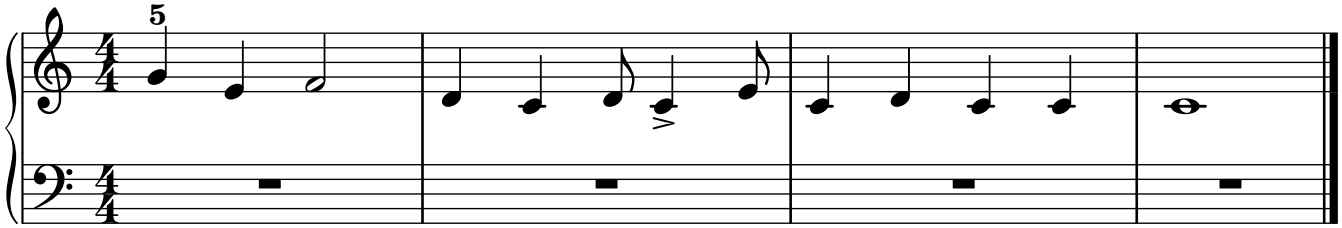
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☐ **5.9**



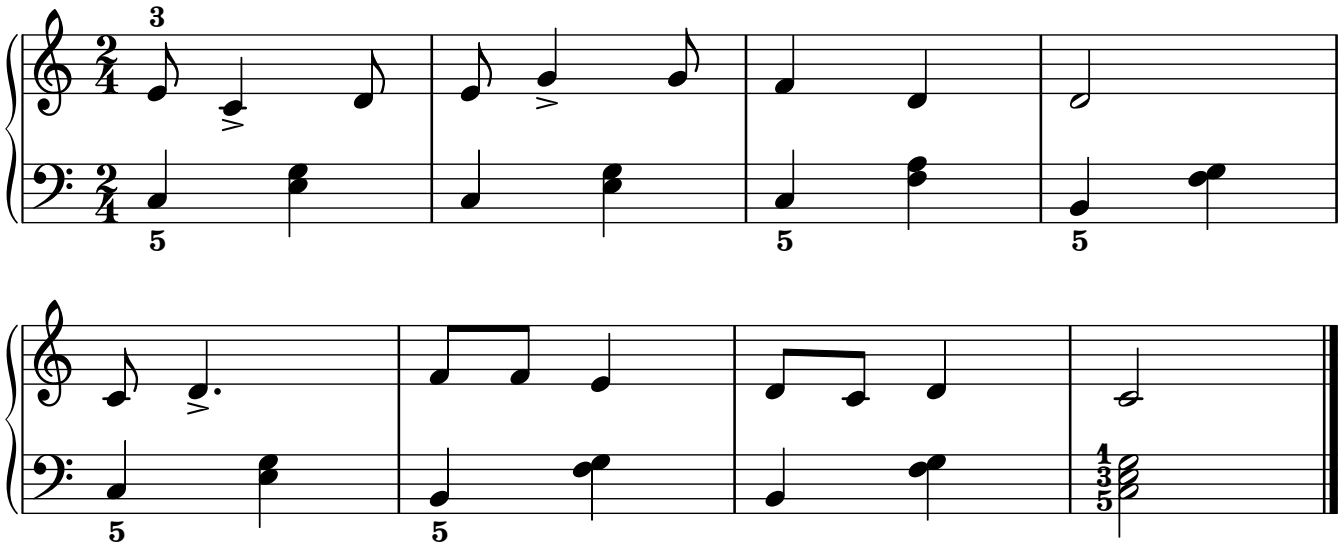
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Part B: Ragtime in 2/4 ♩ = 72

Ragtime in 2/4: a syncopated tune over an oom-pah bass.

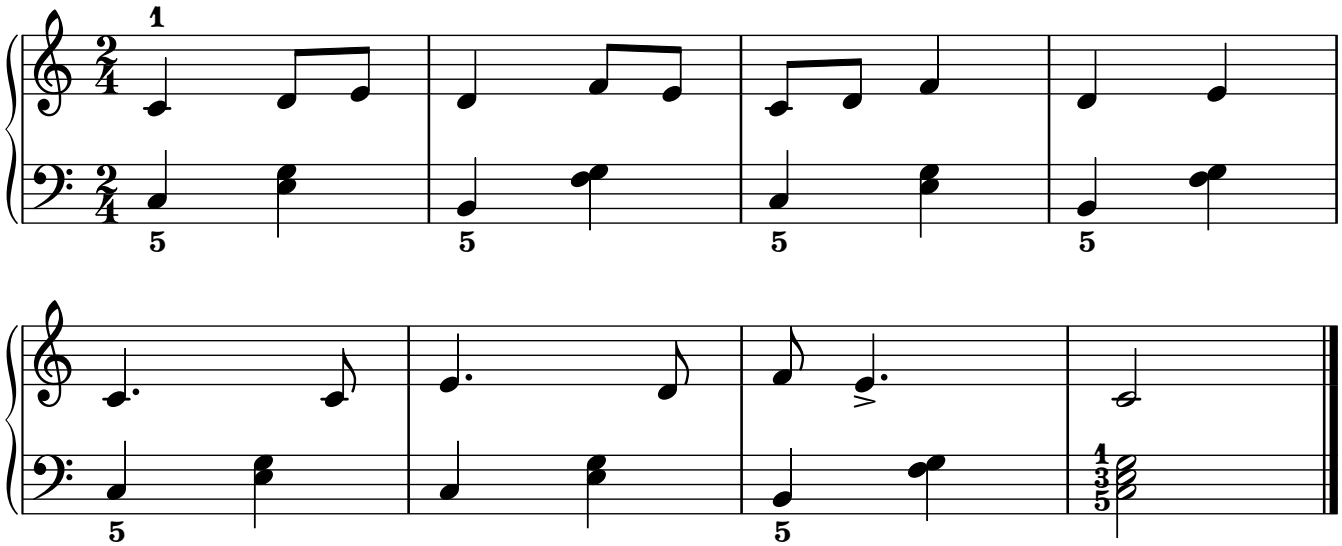
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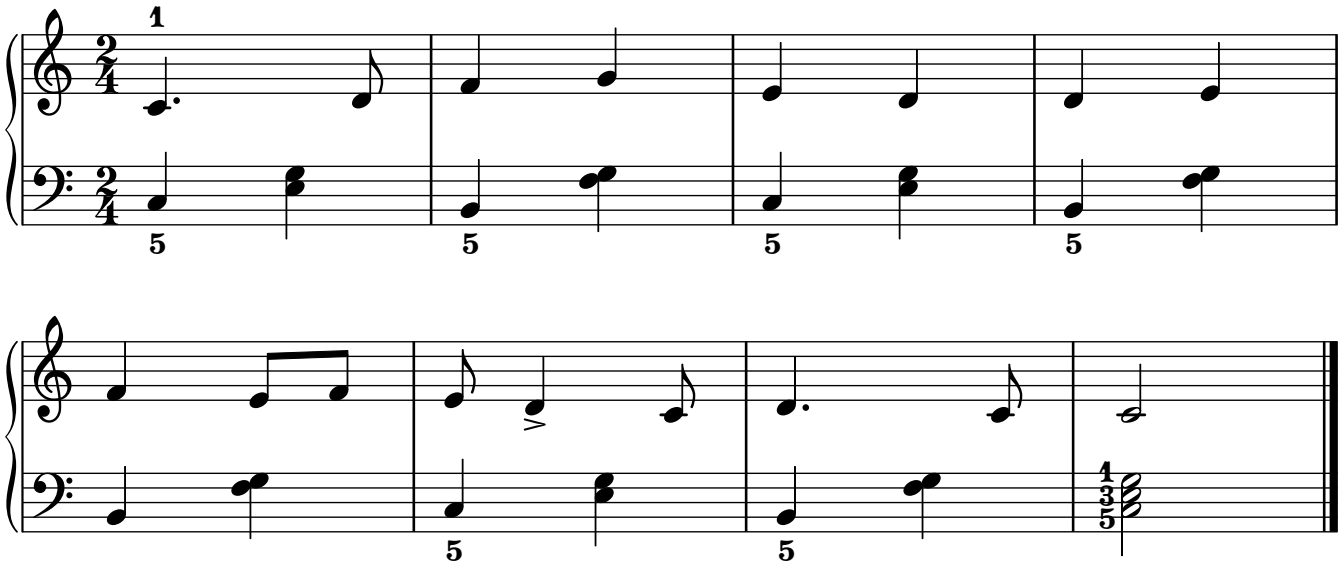
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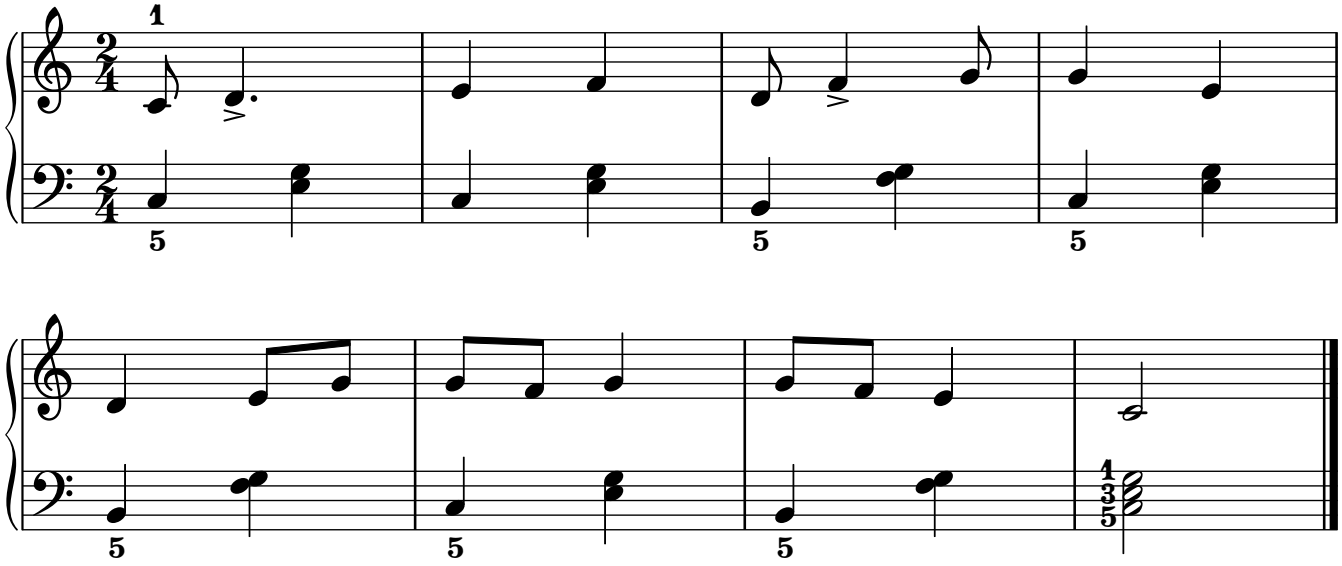
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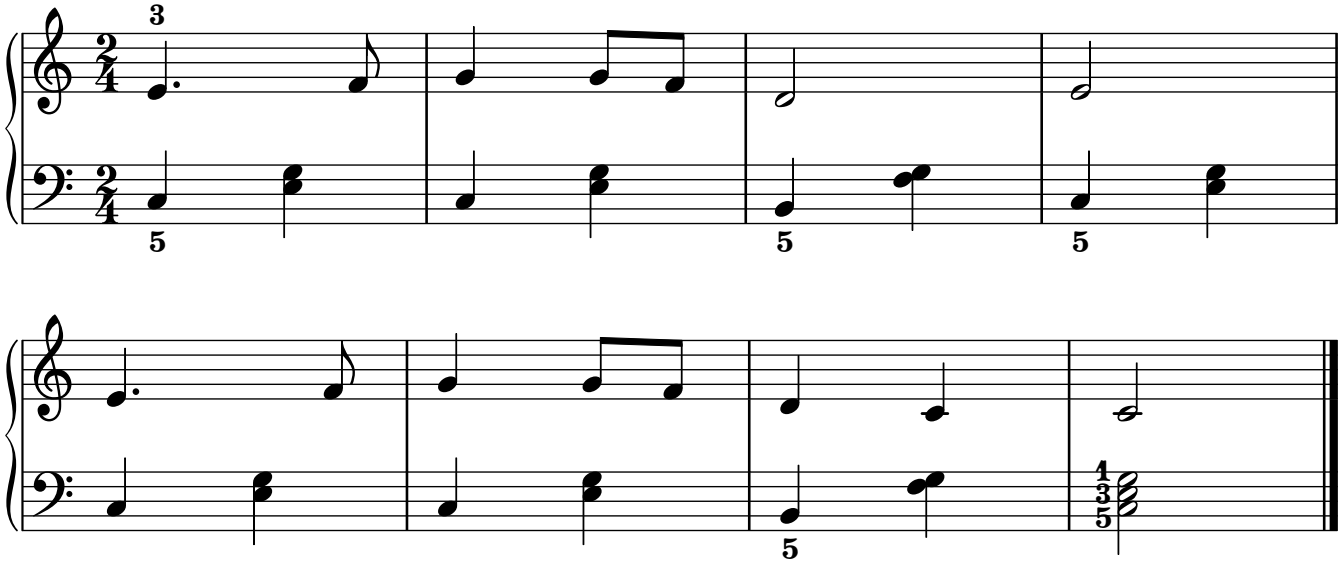
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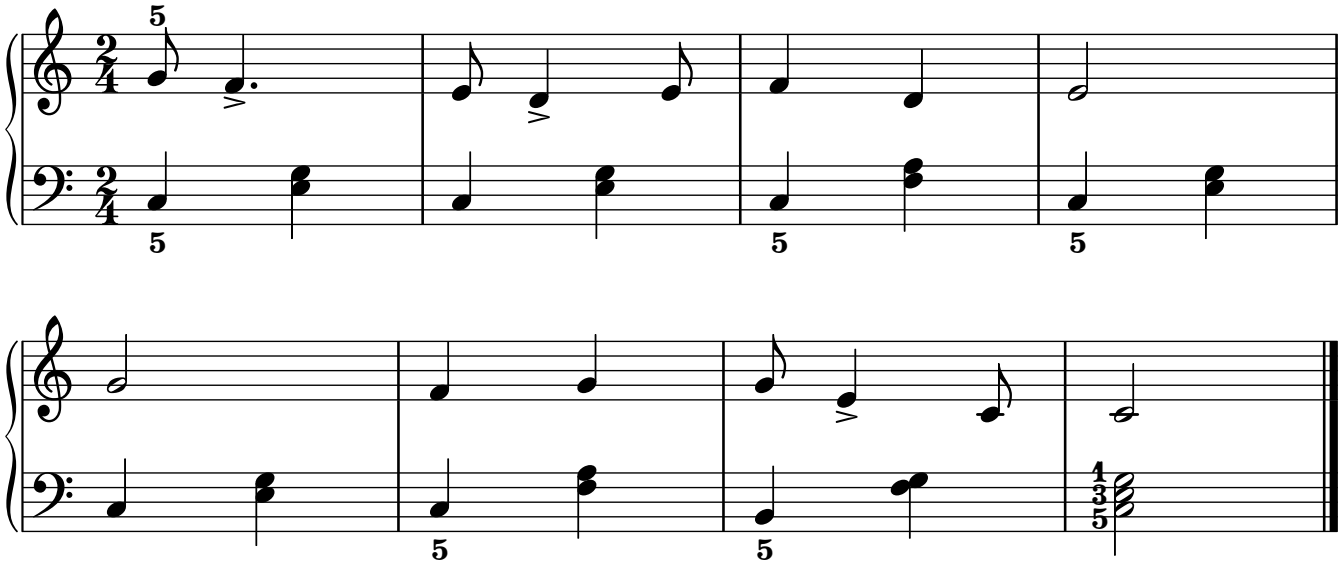
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5.17



5.18



Part C: Across the bar line ♩ = 66

G major: notes tied over the bar line, over block chords.

☐ **5.19**



☐ **5.20**



☐ **5.21**



5.22



5.23



5.24



5.25



5.26



Part D: Syncopation in two voices ♩ = 66

Two voices: a syncopated tune above a steady left hand in half notes.

☐ **5.27**



☐ **5.28**



☐ **5.29**



5.30



5.31



5.32



5.33



5.34



Pieces

Pieces are for playing more than once. Read each one first without stopping, like an exercise; then practise it until it sounds steady and musical.

The Entertainer ♩ = 72

Scott Joplin (1902), first strain - simplified, note values doubled

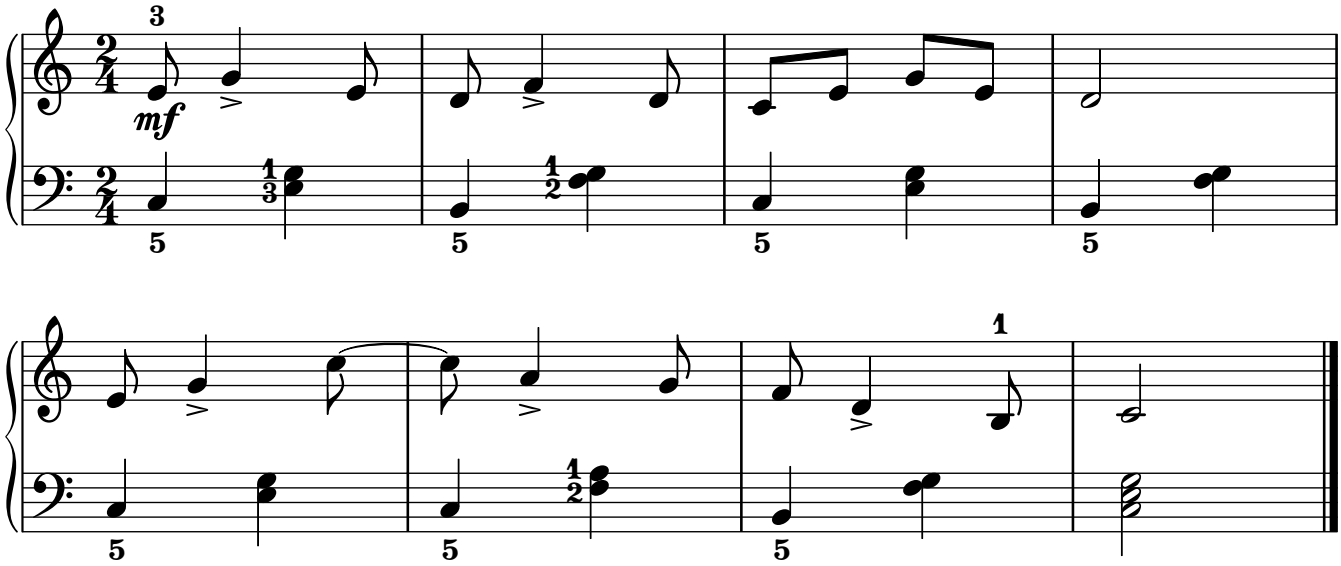
The most famous ragtime. Joplin wrote it in 2/4 with sixteenth notes; here every note lasts twice as long, so it reads in 4/4 with eighths. The tune is an octave lower than written and the bass is a simplified oom-pah. Watch the ties over the bar lines. Source: Mutopia Project no. 263.



Ragtime Rabbit ♩ = 84

Original

Eighth-quarter-eighth in nearly every bar, over an oom-pah bass in 2/4. In bar 5 the last note is tied over the bar line: it starts early and is not played again.



Late for the Train ♩ = 76

Original

Syncopated in G major over steady block chords. Two notes are tied over the bar line (bars 2 and 5).



Checkpoint: ready for Unit 6?

- Play five new Part B to D exercises at the speeds shown: at most one stop each, 9 notes out of 10 right.
- The beat stays steady under every syncopation, and tied notes are not played again.
- When you pass, move on to Unit 6.